# Potential Paths Forward

Recommendation: start with "Better" to fix integration, data and channels within 18 months, designed as the launch pad for the "Best" core replacement

| | **Good**<br>Tactical Technical Upgrades | **Better (recommended)**<br>Modular Foundation Implementation | **Best**<br>End-to-End Cloud-Native Modernization |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Description** | Patch CoreBank issues (batch jobs, monitoring), clean SmartReports feeds, improve mobile/web session handling, rationalize CRM usage slightly | Keep CoreBank but wrap it with an API and integration layer that replaces point-to-point links; add a cloud data lakehouse and BI, one cloud CRM and an API-first omnichannel layer for web and mobile | Replace CoreBank 2000 with a cloud-native core and rebuild the estate on cloud: digital lending, AI/ML fraud detection, cloud DMS and e-signature, SAP S/4HANA, exit the data center |
| **Scope** | CoreBank 2000, SmartReports, MobileSmartApp, OnlineBank Portal, FinCRM; IT operations only, no new platforms | Integration layer, data platform, FinCRM + EmailBanker, MobileSmartApp, OnlineBank Portal, eSignAuth, SmartReports; IT, marketing, digital and risk teams | Entire landscape incl. core, LoanPro, RiskGuard, Documentum, SAP, TradeBank, ATMNet and infrastructure; operating model shifts to product teams, DevOps and managed services |
| **Benefits** | Stabilizes critical services; reduces immediate P1 incident volume; quick IT wins at low cost | Single customer view and trusted, near-real-time reporting; faster feature releases via APIs; digital onboarding and fewer logouts; de-risks a later core swap | Removes the root cause of incidents and tech debt; product launches in weeks; legacy run cost moves toward the 15% peer level; AI-driven personalization and open banking |
| **Tradeoffs** | Doesn't reduce long-term tech debt; missed opportunity for differentiation; no meaningful CX uplift | Core tech debt and P1 risk remain until replaced; temporary dual running; moderate investment and change effort across teams | Highest cost and delivery risk (core data migration, regulatory approval); large skills and change-management gap; benefits arrive late |
| **Timeline** | **3–6 months** | **12–18 months** | **24–36 months, phased** |
| **Objective alignment** | Reduce costs (partly) and minimize disruption; little impact on growth, data or CX goals | Strong: time-to-market, unified data, CX and self-service; partial: cost reduction, new business growth | All five objectives, incl. new business growth via digital innovation and full cost reduction |

Source: SmartBank strategic objectives, systems overview, IT run-cost breakdown and prioritized pain points (solutions A–E)